



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 36

OHIO

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Ohio's family courts and child-welfare system.

105

OHIO FAMILIES ON RECORD · 131
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 18 MONTHS
MEDIAN TIME IN SYSTEM

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 20, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
10 OF 88

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

OHIO AT A GLANCE.

Across 105 Ohio families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 131 51 of 105 families reporting with kids	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$15,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 18 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 53.3% 33.3% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 105	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 2.6	REPORTING FAMILIES 51 of 105	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 10

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Ohio families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF OHIO FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	55	\$15,000	\$76,175	\$4,189,600
Lost Wages	51	\$5,000	\$125,753	\$6,413,390
Other Court Fees	37	\$500	\$4,069	\$150,565
Therapy / Evaluations	43	\$1,000	\$7,343	\$315,760
Reunification Services	46	\$100	\$2,810	\$129,260
GAL Fees	52	\$1,550	\$6,249	\$324,950
Asset Loss ¹	44	\$4,250	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$27,400	—	—

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$4,250) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		18	1.5 yrs
Mean months lost		30	2.5 yrs
Total across all families		1,682	140.2 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · OHIO

Most families documenting in Ohio are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Currently involved / "S...		40	38%
Case closed (within th...		13	12%
Case closed (more tha...		11	10%
I am currently stuck in ...		3	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and ...		49	47%
Family Court Only		30	29%
CPS (Child Protective ...		3	3%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		25	24%
3 – 5 years		22	21%
Over 10 years		11	10%
6 months – 1 year		10	10%
1-3 years		9	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		34	32%
No Contact / Total Los...		28	27%
50/50 Joint		12	11%
Full Custody		11	10%
Children in Foster Care		9	9%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Hancock		6	6%
Hamilton		4	4%
Summit		4	4%
Licking		3	3%
Williams		3	3%
Allen		3	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Acc...		29	28%
Other: (Short answer)		15	14%
False Accusations CPS...		12	11%
Family Court		12	11%
High Conflict Divorce		8	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — OHIO

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Terminated my Parental Rights in Fraud and destroyed my children.

— PATSY

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Removed my kids to ex parte without letting my attorney know.

— OHIO PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM OHIO

Because I'm deaf - system use my abuser and his mother as their primary and believe them because they have voice and I don't. They lie a lot about me. Judge refused to see my proof motion. They never on my side. I even show them my proof of abuser hit me and raped me. The judge [...]

— AVRIL

They took away my rights as a mother to raise my children as I see fit. I was always either a stay at home mom or I worked as needed and was forced to work full-time. They took my kids away during the school time, but not during the summer, because I didn't believe in the very [...]

— KAYLEIGH

False claims to CPS by my boyfriend's ex girlfriend. Kids were on a safety plan for 2 weeks while I got drug tested and came back negative

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took my grandson away and gave him to the abusers who then kept him and his siblings from coming home to me

— ROBIN

This system has ripped my kids from wverything they knew. They have caused hurt anger and my kids are suffering and lashing out.

— MERSADEES

The depression and hurt of not being able to a mother to your children is devastating. My children suffered abuse and mental health abuse.

— BELINDA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I have been grieving my kids that are STILL ALIVE because of the Clark county ohio family court!! LOST MEMORIES, LOST TIMES, AND A BONDS STOLEN . just like that....gone I LOVE YOU JULIUS AND BRYLON

— BRIANNA

This system stole all 5 of my son's children from our ENTIRE family. Even though I had 2 of these kids as an emergency placement, and kinship placement of my nephew, these children have been kept from the entire paternal side.

— ROBYN

Illegal alien with a conviction of sexual abuse of a child was given full custody of a minor child. Parental (entire maternal family) alienation has been endorsed by family court.

— ROBYN

Shattered the relationship with son, destroyed my son's image of me, his self esteem, his identity, placed him in the home with the abuser.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

An assistant prosecuting attorney acting as a civil custody lawyer al fight and suppressed a 25 year violent criminal history for his private client. Attorneys judges, GALCPS and even neighboring counties are working together, not in the best interest of the child, but in the [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I cry every day, it was always me and my son, every day since he was born, I look at the pictures of me and him together my son clinging onto me when he was little and I break down and cry, we used to order pizza and have pizza and movie night once a month, I taught my son how [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has caused a ginormous splinter in the bond I hold with my children. Refused and erased my ancestral traditions and our way of life.

— RAVEN

Allowed this person to commit criminal crimes against me by not allowing me to see my children and has gotten away with every single one.

— SARA

Took away our entire lives. Completely destroyed our mental health. Made my children believe I'm the bad guy and don't love them or care about them. Told them I wasn't their mother and their father wasn't their father.

— ALEXANDREA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system has single-handedly divided and destroyed my sense of security, my sense of peace, my children from my life and allowed the abuser to publicly look like a hero, forcing the mother to pay a child support for two kids while residing in Ohio and kids being in California [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has caused severe trauma for both of us. My daughter is not getting the medical care she needs, and I worry about her safety everyday. My daughter already had anxiety prior to separation. they destroyed our bond and all the good things ive done her whole life.

— HEATHER

Turned me into a civil rights activist.

— CAREY ANN

took my daughter who was sexually abused, and put her back with her abuser in the same home the abuse occurred. she then got molested again in under a month of contact

— HEIDI

Kids taken without hearing. Zero evidence of abuse or neglect. When I responded and called them all out on Facebook I was punished with jail time and more lost time with my children. My ex and my ex boss got together and turned my posts into my coal mining job for 12 years I was [...]

— NICK

My daughter wants to move back with me no abuse or anything judge just sides with his attorney and can't even tell me what I've done wrong I swore at her in a text

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Shattered the relationship with son, destroyed my son's image of me, his self esteem, his identity, placed him in the home with the abuser.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— BRIANNA

Alienation, psychological abused, thoughts of suicide, financial inability, loss of my heart

— RHIANNA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system falsely accused my fiancé, and then even after her charge have been dismissed. I am now still being punished years later.

— RACHEL

Created litigation abuse, DARVO, violates the constitution land of law, me allowing to speak, violation of due process.

— JESSICA

They destroyed our confidence and consistency. They destroyed my child's mental health and mine. They did nothing but lie to help make that happen.

— ANNA

Butler and warren county ohio destroyed my family and took time I will never get back

— JESSICA

The courts didn't just take my rights — they took my child, my time, my voice, my safety, and the chance to protect the one person who depended on me to survive.

— TACI

Despite having a protection order and evidence of abuse and coercive control and opposing party not following any court orders (psych evaluation and hair strand test) and having multiple contempt of court, the GAL is suggesting joint custody.

— EMILY

Complete and total destruction of our happy, loving family with use of psychological warfare to all 3 of my children and myself!

— RENE

It has caused further trauma, cause children to cry out for help and be denied so they turn to committing crimes as thats what they are being taught instead of protected. It tears apart siblings and grandparents and great grandparents.

— CATHERINE

The system falsely accused my fiancé, and then even after her charge have been dismissed. I am now still being punished years later.

— RACHEL

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



“This system drained our family emotionally and financially, forcing us to spend everything we had just to be heard, while separating us from our children without timely answers or accountability. It turned protection into punishment and survival into a constant fight.”

— BRITNEY

The system has completely broke us and failed us. Out of all the people that I know in our county it has lost their children to the system. I am the only one that was able to get mine back..

— MATTALYNN

Took my kids out of a loving home to place them where ever they could following all the recommendations they set to have unsupervised visits so we can move on to overnight and then home but I never one time got more parenting time or any of the unsupervised visits or overnight. [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took phone calls away my visits ect please call I have so much to say

— TRISHA

Has made my life harder financially, mentally and it's made me lose hope that the system is good and fair and needed

— ROBERT

Violated my rights kidnapped my child and used her estate as leverage of extortion in commerce against me using a fictitious scarecrow and tricking me into their jurisdiction to be used in commerce as a current day slave.

— HARLEY

My family has turned their back on each other has broken sibling bonds and made some of my kids rebel agaist the system and caused ttust issues against the system

— ANDREA

Traumatized me and my son

— TRISHA

The court process has turned what should have been a child-focused custody matter into years of instability, forced separation, and emotional strain on my children and me. The lack of accountability has caused lasting harm to our family relationships

— ANNA

67 Ohio parents submitted ranked quotes. 44 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/oh.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Ohio report comes from Ohio respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Ohio — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 105 Ohio families reporting here are not the universe of Ohio families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics (email + name + submission date) are applied before aggregation. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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